Buddhist organizations. The function of the group was as much civic as religious. The educational outlook encouraged both religion and modernity.

Eventually the YMBA became the cornerstone of patriotic grassroots work in Burma. In part, the group's focus became somewhat reactionary as more Burmese became disenchanted with modern society. Many Burmese also felt a loss of national identity that the YMBA seemed to connect to. The YMBA did champion a more significant role for lay people regarding religious authority. This message was appealing to Burmese who were emerging middle class, modern, and Buddhist. The initial support the group received from colonial authorities soon dissipated. The group sought to impact the morality of society by condemning intoxicants and in general immoral behavior.

Following World War I, Burmese nationalism accelerated as the YMBA recreated itself as the General Council of Burman Associations, or GCBA. The leaders of the organization were not monks or professors, but English-trained lawyers. By 1920, student protests exploded in Burma. Sir Reginald Craddock, the lieutenant governor of Burma proposed creating Rangoon University. The structure of the university would be modeled after the American Baptist and Rangoon Colleges, which in general terms was elitist with only the wealthy being admitted. The students demanded admission based on ability and the curriculum being broadened. The Burmese students wanted a modern educational system developed, which would in turn further the goals of the nationalist cause.

FACTIONALISM WITHIN THE NATIONALIST MOVEMENT

Within a few years the unity of the GCBA was fractured. Followers of U Chit Hlaing wanted a type of “home rule” where Burma would be completely divorced from India and given a much greater degree of autonomy. Eventually this would in turn lead to full independence. The minority position championed by U Ba Pe urged continued unity with India in the hopes that the nationalist gains of the much better organized Indian National Congress would trickle down to the Burmese nationalists. This would expedite independence. The “home rule” concept was the majority position within the nationalist movement.